



Web3 & NFTs in 2026

From Speculation to Real Utility

By Samuel Je Christian · Web3 Corner Date: May 23, 2026



What Happened to NFTs?

In 2021, a JPEG sold for \$69 million. Celebrities were launching NFT collections. Trading volumes hit billions per week. Everyone was talking about NFTs.

Then the market crashed. Volumes collapsed 95% from their peak, most collections went to near-zero, and headlines declared that "NFTs are dead."

But something interesting happened while everyone was busy writing obituaries. **The builders kept building.** And NFTs quietly transformed into something far more useful than JPEGs.



What NFTs Actually Are — Revisited

NFT stands for Non-Fungible Token.

- **Non-fungible** means unique and irreplaceable. One Bitcoin is identical to another, but one NFT is distinct from every other NFT.
- An NFT is a **verifiable proof of ownership** stored permanently on a blockchain.

What it represents can be almost anything:

- 🎨 A piece of digital art
- 🎫 A concert ticket
- ⚔️ A gaming item
- 🪪 A membership credential
- 🏠 A real estate deed
- 📺 A loyalty point
- 🎓 An academic certificate

The speculation era focused on the first one. **The utility era is about all the rest.**



NFTs in 2026 — The Transformation

The speculative collectibles bubble of 2021-2022 has given way to a utility-driven NFT ecosystem.

[!IMPORTANT] Today, NFTs represent event tickets, gaming assets, membership credentials, loyalty points, and real-world asset representation — a profound transformation from the speculative collectibles era.

Here is what NFTs actually do in 2026:



Real NFT Use Cases — 2026

1. Event Tickets

Your concert ticket is an NFT. This offers massive benefits over traditional ticketing:

-  Cannot be counterfeited or forged.
-  Resale markets are fully transparent and traceable.
-  Artists get secondary sale royalties automatically.
-  Unlocks additional physical or digital perks tied to the token.
-  Proof of attendance is permanently recorded on-chain.

2. Gaming Assets

The item you earned in a game, the character you built over 500 hours, or the rare weapon that dropped after weeks:

- In traditional gaming, these belong entirely to the publisher.
- As NFTs, **they belong to you**. You can sell them when you're done, trade them, or use them across different games.
- The projects getting it right make the game fun first and the ownership invisible second.

3. Membership Credentials

Access to a community, proof of membership, or verification of professional credentials.

- **University Degrees:** Instantly verifiable by any employer, unforgeable, and permanently owned by you.
- **Professional Certifications:** An on-chain record that updates automatically and is portable across platforms.

4. Loyalty Points — The Biggest Opportunity

Traditional loyalty programs are siloed, expiring, and often worthless. NFT-based loyalty points are tradeable across brands, never expire on-chain, and carry a verifiable history of your customer relationship.

- **Examples:** Starbucks Odyssey and Nike's .SWOOSH digital collectibles pioneered this space, refining how brands build digital-physical relationships.

5. Real World Asset (RWA) Representation

A tokenized property deed, fractional ownership of a building, or a bond on-chain.

- The NFT standard is what makes individual asset ownership on-chain verifiable and transferable.
- Each tokenized property is represented as a unique NFT, with fractional shares tracked by the same secure ledger.



Why Most NFT Projects Failed

93% of NFT collections from 2021-2022 are now worth essentially nothing due to consistent flaws:

-  **No utility:** JPEGs with no use case have value only as long as someone else wants to buy them.
-  **Bad tokenomics:** Unlimited supply and no reason to hold or participate in an

ecosystem.

- ❌ **Celebrity-driven hype:** Cash grabs where founders abandoned the collection after launch.
- ❌ **No community ownership:** Projects extracted value from buyers instead of sharing it with them.
- ❌ **Infrastructure gaps:** High gas fees and a terrible user experience prior to Layer 2 maturity.



The NFT Projects That Survived — Why

- 🦍 **Yuga Labs (Bored Apes, CryptoPunks):** Maintained strong brand recognition, granted intellectual property (IP) rights to holders, and expanded their digital-physical ecosystem.
- 🎴 **Gods Unchained:** A blockchain-based trading card game where cards are owned NFTs. Cards hold value because the game itself is fun and actively played.
- ⚽ **Sorare:** Fantasy sports with NFT player cards licensed by real football clubs. It features millions of players and real utility built into the core gaming experience.
- 🏠 **Real Estate Tokenization:** Fractional property ownership via NFTs, with platforms like DroppRWA securing \$12.5 billion in mandates, shrinking settlement times from days to seconds.



The Technology Improving in 2026

- ⚡ **Dynamic NFTs (dNFTs):** NFTs that change based on real-world data (e.g., a sports card NFT that updates stats after every game via an oracle).
- 🔒 **Soul-Bound Tokens (SBTs):** Non-transferable NFTs used as on-chain credentials (degrees, reputation scores, digital identities) to prove who you are rather than what you own.
- ➡️ **Account Abstraction + NFTs:** Eliminates gas fees and setup friction. NFT ownership is now as easy as receiving an email attachment.



The One-Line Summary

NFTs in 2026 are not JPEGs — they are verifiable digital ownership certificates for tickets, gaming assets, credentials, loyalty programs, and real-world assets, quietly powering the infrastructure of the digital economy.

Follow @Samuel_web3 on X <https://web3-corner.netlify.app/> © 2026 Web3 Corner · Samuel Je Christian